

Word family: **past / pasts**

Base word: past

Plural: pasts

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / noun (名詞) / preposition (介詞) / adverb (副詞)

Your sentence:

> "...the tiny details that most of us walk straight **past**."

Meaning in this passage

Here, **past** means **beyond and continuing on the other side of a person, place, or thing after passing it**.

The phrase **walk straight past** means that people continue walking beyond the small details without stopping to notice them.

繁體中文： **經過某人或某物所在的位置並繼續向前，到達其另一邊或更遠的位置**

中文翻譯：

> "...the tiny details that most of us walk straight **past**."

「.....那些大部分人都會**直接走過 / 經過而沒有留意**的小細節。」

Here:

walk past something = 從某人或某物旁邊經過並繼續向前

1. **past + person/place/object (位置) — 經過；越過**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: To or on the farther side of a person, place, or thing after moving beyond it.

Practice 1 — Original

> "Most of us walk straight **past** those tiny details."

「我們大部分人都會**直接走過**那些細小的細節。」

Practice 2

> “I walked **past** the station without noticing it.”

「我沒有留意到車站，直接**走過去了**。」

Practice 3

> “She drove **past** my house on her way to work.”

「她上班途中駕車**經過**我家。」

past = 從某人、地方或物件旁邊經過，並繼續到其另一邊或更遠的位置

Common:

- * walk past
- * drive past
- * run past
- * go past
- * look past

The movement verb changes, but the underlying spatial concept remains the same.

2. **past + time (時間)** — 超過某個時間點

Here, **past** means later than a particular time.

Practice 4

> “It was already **past midnight** when we left.”

「我們離開時已經**過了午夜十二點**。」

Practice 5

> “The meeting continued **past six o'clock**.”

「會議一直持續到**超過六點**。」

past + time = 時間已經越過某個指定時刻，處於更晚的時間

This is figuratively related to spatial movement:

> move beyond a place → move beyond a point in time

But for learners, the temporal meaning is distinct enough to teach separately.

3. **past = earlier than the present (過去的) — 過去的 ; 以前的**

As an adjective, **past** can describe a period, event, experience, or situation that occurred before now.

Practice 6

> “Over the **past** few years, the neighbourhood has changed a lot.”

「在**過去幾年**裡，這個社區改變了很多。」

Practice 7

> “We can learn from **past** mistakes.”

「我們可以從**過去的錯誤**中學習。」

past + noun = 發生於現在之前的某個時期或屬於以前的事情

Common:

- * past experience
- * past mistakes
- * past events
- * past few years
- * past performance

These all belong to the same “before the present” sense.

4. **the past (過去時期 / 往事) — 過去 ; 往事**

As a noun, **the past** means the period of time before the present, or events and experiences from that period.

Practice 8

> “People often remember the **past** differently.”

「人們對**過去 / 往事**的記憶往往不同。」

Practice 9

> “He rarely talks about his **past**.”

「他很少談及自己的**過去 / 往事**。」

the past = 現在之前的時間，以及在那段時間發生的事情或個人經歷

Compare:

> **past mistakes**

> = 過去的錯誤

> **the past**

> = 過去 / 往事

The adjective and noun forms are grammatically different, though semantically closely related.

5. **be past + stage/age/condition** (階段 / 年齡 / 狀態) — 已經超過；已經不再處於

Here, **past** means having moved beyond a particular stage, age, condition, or possibility.

Practice 10

> “The fruit is **past its best**.”

「這些水果已經**過了最佳狀態**。」

Practice 11

> “He is **past the age** when he wants to stay out all night.”

「他已經**過了會想整晚在外面的年紀**。」

be past something = 已經超過某個階段、年齡、狀態或最佳時期

This develops naturally from “beyond a point,” but the figurative application is common enough to make explicit.

6. **past + limit/problem/point** (界線 / 難關) — 越過；渡過

Past can describe being beyond a difficult stage, limit, or obstacle.

Practice 12

> “Once we got ****past**** the difficult first stage, the project became easier.”

「我們一旦****渡過 / 越過****最困難的第一階段，項目就容易多了。」

Practice 13

> “She is finally ****past**** the worst part of the illness.”

「她終於****捱過了 / 渡過了****病情最嚴重的階段。」

****past a difficulty/stage = 已經越過某個困難、障礙或階段，不再停留在其中****

For database counting, I would merge this with Meaning 5 under the broader concept:

> ****beyond a point/stage/limit****

7. ****past = beyond someone's ability/understanding/control (能力 / 理解 / 控制) — 超出；無法處理****

A further figurative use describes something that lies beyond a person's ability or control.

Practice 14

> “The problem is ****past**** my understanding.”

「這個問題****超出我的理解能力****。」

Practice 15

> “The situation may already be ****past**** repair.”

「這個情況可能已經****無法修補 / 超出可挽救範圍****。」

****past someone's ability / past repair = 已超越某種能力、可能性或可處理範圍****

This is conceptually another “beyond a limit” use, so I would not inflate it into a fully separate core meaning.

8. ****past = further than / on the other side of a point (靜態位置) — 在……另一邊；超過****

Past does not always require a movement verb.

Practice 16

> “The café is just **past** the bridge.”

「那間咖啡店就在**過了橋之後不遠的位置**。」

Practice 17

> “There is a small shop **past** the traffic lights.”

「**過了交通燈之後**有一間小店。」

past + landmark = 位於某個地標之後 / 另一邊的位置

This shares the same spatial sense as Meaning 1 and should be merged with it for core counting.

9. **half past / ten past, etc. (報時) —點過.....分**

This is a very common fixed time construction.

Practice 18

> “It’s **half past six**.”

「現在是**六點半**。」

Practice 19

> “The train leaves at ten **past** eight.”

「火車在**八點十分**開出。」

minutes past + hour = 某個整點之後已過了若干分鐘

This grows from the temporal “beyond a point in time” sense rather than requiring a separate lexical meaning.

Important distinction: **past vs passed**

This is one of the most important learner contrasts.

past

can be:

- * preposition
- * adjective
- * noun
- * adverb

> “We walked **past** the station.”

「我們走過車站。」

passed

is the past tense / past participle of **pass**.

> “We **passed** the station.”

「我們經過了車站。」

So:

- > walk **past** ✓
- > walked **past** ✓
- > **passed** the station ✓

But:

> walked **passed** the station ✗

This is a classic spelling/grammar distinction.

Important distinction: **past vs previous**

past

generally refers broadly to something before the present.

> “past experience”

= 過去經驗

previous

often means the one immediately or specifically before the current one.

> “the previous meeting”

= 上一次會議

So:

past = broadly earlier than now

previous = earlier in a sequence, often directly preceding

Important distinction: **past vs former**

past

often describes an earlier period, experience, event, or general previous state.

> past mistakes

> past experience

former

usually describes a role, status, relationship, or identity that once applied but no longer does.

> former neighbour

> former president

So:

> **past experience** 

> **former experience** usually unnatural

> **former neighbour** 

> **past neighbour** usually unnatural

This is a useful contrast with the word you curated earlier.

Important distinction: **past vs ago**

Both relate to earlier time, but grammar differs.

past

> “the past three years”

= 過去三年

ago

is measured backward from now:

> “three years ago”

= 三年前

Not:

> “three ago years” ❌

Fixed expression: **in the past**

Practice 20

> “People communicated very differently **in the past**.”

「人們**過去 / 以前**的溝通方式很不同。」

Practice 21

> “I made that mistake several times **in the past**.”

「我**以前**曾幾次犯過同樣的錯。」

in the past = 在現在之前的某段時間；以前

This belongs naturally to the noun **the past** sense.

Fixed expression: **past it**

In informal English, **past it** can mean no longer as capable, fashionable, useful, or successful

as before, often because of age.

Practice 22

> “Some people said the athlete was **past it**, but he proved them wrong.”

「有人說那位運動員已經**過了巔峰、不中用了**，但他證明他們錯了。」

Practice 23

> “That technology is completely **past it** now.”

「那種科技現在已經**完全過時了**。」

past it = 因年齡、時間或發展而不再具有從前的能力、價值或時代適切性

Register:

informal, especially British English

This is useful, but I would treat it as a fixed-expression extension.

Related form / lexical note: **past**

Unlike many words in your database, **past** has a very small derivational family.

The learning value comes mainly from its **multiple grammatical roles**:

- * adjective
- * noun
- * preposition
- * adverb

and from its broad semantic idea of:

> **being before the present or beyond a point**

The Golden Manual specifically says that a small word family should be left small rather than padded with artificial derivatives.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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past + person/place/object — spatial	從某人、地方或物件旁邊經過，或位於其另一邊 / 更遠的位置
past + time	時間已經超過某個指定時刻，處於更晚的時間
past + noun — earlier	發生於或屬於現在之前某個時期的；過去的
the past	現在之前的時間，以及在那段時間發生的事情或個人經歷
be past a stage/age/condition	已經超過某個階段、年齡、狀態、最佳時期或界線
past someone's ability / past repair	已超出某種能力、控制、理解或可挽救的範圍；屬於「超越界線」的延伸
minutes past + hour	某個整點之後已過若干分鐘
past it	因年齡、時間或發展而不再像從前般有能力、有效或合時宜

For your original sentence

> “...the tiny details that most of us walk straight ****past****.”

The exact meaning is:

****past = 從某人或某物旁邊經過並繼續向前，到達其另一邊或更遠的位置****

So:

****walk straight past something = 直接從某物旁邊走過，完全沒有停下來或留意****

For your database, I would count ****5 genuinely useful core polysemy/polyfunctionality meanings**** for ****past****:

1. ****spatial — beyond / on the other side of a person, place, or object****
2. ****temporal — later than a particular time****
3. ****adjective — belonging to an earlier time****
4. ****noun — the period/events before the present****
5. ****figurative — beyond a stage, limit, condition, ability, or possibility****

I would merge ****past a difficult stage / past repair / past its best**** under #5, and treat ****half past****, ****in the past****, and ****past it**** as useful fixed constructions rather than inflate the core count.